

TOURISM STATS

- Fifteen per cent of India's total foreign exchange earnings, from tourism, come from Goa.
- This year Goa is expecting over 850 charter flights and more than 25 lakh tourists.
- Total revenue earned for fiscal year 2006-07 from tourism: Rs 4,000 crore (as against revenue of Rs 3,700 crore from 2005-06)
- Budget allocation for tourism increased from Rs 3.5 crore in 2000 to Rs 31 crore in 2006-07
- Total tourist arrivals in 2007: 25,97,443 (domestic: 22,08,986; foreign: 3,88,457)
- Goa tourism industry has contributed \$300 million (Rs 120 crore) as foreign exchange in 2006

TOTAL NO. OF HOTELS: 2,409

CATEGORY A	45
CATEGORY B	156
CATEGORY C	340
CATEGORY D	1,868
TOTAL NO. OF ROOMS	2,1594
TOTAL NO. OF BEDS	40,480

As on December 31, 2007

INTERNATIONAL TOURISTS

UK	78,904
DENMARK	2,401
SWITZERLAND	2,811
SWEDEN	12,098
FINLAND	7,128
RUSSIA	37,887
ITALY	1,683

For the season between October 2007 and March 2008



ASHESH SHAH

While Russians dominate the trade at Morjim, Nigerians at Calangute, the French and Israelis rule at Palolim. Drugs like cocaine and ecstasy are imported and sold at rave parties in Goa during the tourist season. Last year, the Goa Police had seized narcotics worth Rs 1.25 crore and registered a total of 31 cases. It is also alleged that the police are hand-in-glove with the drug mafia. The recent murder of British teenager, Scarlett Keeling, which has become a cause celebre, exposed the levels at which the drug trade operates. Her bruised body was found to have heavy traces of drugs and alcohol and she had also been raped. The co-owner of the shack where she ended up in at 5 a.m., and

THE DRUG TRADE FUELS TOURISM AND ALSO BRINGS THE WRONG TYPE OF VISITOR TO GOA

where she died shortly after, was arrested for her rape and murder.

The bigger threat to Goa comes from the builder mafia. The holiday hotspot is a goldmine for builders with people from outside scrambling for property—at any cost. Property consultants say prices have tripled in the last two years with big players like Rahejas, DLF, Emaar and Peninsula entering the realty market. “It is fashionable to own a house in Goa even if you spend only a month there every year. Investors buy expensive properties and keep them locked, causing dearth in availability, which results in high rates,” says Somayaji.

The last decade has witnessed a rampant and unchecked property boom in the state. Builders from Mumbai and Delhi have bought large tracts of land to construct housing complexes, often in violation of the existing norms. The plush Aldeia-de-Goa complex of high-end villas at Navshe village is alleged to have cut the hill beyond the permitted gradient, chopped trees and buried the fertile line. “Violations happen all the time. If you have money to burn, you come here,” says Oscar Rebello, convener of Goa Bachao Abhiyan. Fertile agricultural land is being sold for a pittance to give way to high-rises. “Politicians have promised builders to get land converted for a price,” says Rajan Narayan, editor of *Goa Observer*. A 650-apartment housing complex is coming up in the midst of tiny Carmona village, causing concern amongst activists over pressure on civic services. “Unplanned development continues under the benign gaze of the authorities. New constructions strains resources and spoils the character of the village,” says Rebello.

Soon after the Goa Property show in Delhi earlier this month, cardiologist and activist Fransisco Colaco had urged Goans to save their land from property sharks and the ban the sale of land to non-Goans. The state supposedly has four powerful builder lobbies which are affiliated to different politicians and the indiscriminate re-zoning of land in the controversial Regional Plan 2011 and then the SEZs was allegedly the result of a politician-builder nexus. “In the early '70s, the mining lobby was all-powerful but now it's the builder lobby that calls the shots,” says Fredrick Noronha, a journalist. Amending a 100-year-old Act, the Goa Government has finally decided to ban the sale of land to foreigners in the state as part of public policy.

The murder of Keeling has also forced the Government and the police to take some strict